Lab 33: One guard clause doesn't need a plan

Topic 3: Claude Code Configuration & Workflows · Task 3.4: Determine when to use plan mode vs direct execution

Runs on Simulator 2: Code Generation with Claude Code · Run in class

Source: SkillCertPro practice exam Part 1, Q34 (unofficial third-party question)

Commit to an answer first

A teammate wants Claude Code to add one guard clause to a single known function so it rejects negative quantities, then run the existing unit test for that file. The relevant file path and expected behavior are already known, and no API, schema, or architectural changes are involved. What should the developer do?

A. Start with bypass permissions so Claude can edit and test without permission prompts.

B. Enter plan mode first, review a plan, then approve implementation after exploration.

C. Ask Claude Code to make the small change directly and run the specified test.

D. Switch to accept-edits mode first, let Claude edit, then inspect the diff afterward.

Simulate the solution

```
# In the browser: open Simulator 2, then Lab 33
cd labs
uv run serve.py

# In Claude Code, from the labs folder
/lab 33

# In a terminal, from simulators/simulator-2-code-generation/
uv run casekit.py --case UC-34
```

What you should see

No plan mode. quantity.js changes, node --test runs, three tests pass.

No plan mode: Claude edits src/utils/quantity.js, runs node --test tests/quantity.test.js and reports three passing tests.

Open `simulators/simulator-2-code-generation/evidence/` and find it yourself.

The answer

C. Ask directly, then run the named test.

For a small, well-scoped change, ask for the outcome directly and include a verification step. The best-practices guidance says plan mode adds overhead: if you can describe the diff in one sentence, skip the plan. Asking directly does not mean bypassing permissions. In the default mode reads run freely, while edits, shell commands and network requests can still pause for approval.

Why the others fail

A. Permission mode is unrelated to whether a plan is needed, and bypassing permissions is unnecessary risk.

B. Planning overhead for a one-line, fully specified change.

D. Changes approval behaviour without adding anything this task needs.

Check yourself

- the single known file was edited directly
- the specified test ran and passed

- no plan or permission-mode change was needed for a one-sentence diff

Now change one thing

Set LAB_MODEL=claude-sonnet-5-5, rerun, and compare the result and the cost line in evidence/.

Third-party practice material from SkillCertPro, reconstructed from a video transcript in the Tertiary Markdown Vault. Not a real exam item. Wording may differ from the original.